another, may have reaggregated into just such a jumbled, patchy, unfinished world as Miranda is today.

For me, there's something eerie about the pictures of dusky Miranda, because I can remember so well when it was only a faint point of light almost lost in the glare of Uranus, discovered through great difficulty by dint of the astronomer's skills and patience. In only half a lifetime it has gone from an undiscovered world to a destination whose ancient and idiosyncratic secrets have been at least partially revealed.

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*There was one moment in the last 4,000 years when all seven of these celestial bodies were clustered tightly together. Just before dawn on March 4, 1953 B.C., the crescent Moon was at the horizon. Venus, Mercury, Mars, Saturn, and Jupiter were strung out like jewels on a necklace near the great square in the constellation Pegasus—near the spot from which in our time the Perseid meteor shower emanates. Even casual watchers of the sky must have been transfixed by the event. What was it—a communion of the gods? According to the astronomer David Pankenier of Lehigh University and later Kevin Pang of JPL, this event was the starting point for the planetary cycles of the ancient Chinese astronomers.

There is no other time in the last 4,000 years (or in the next) when the dance of the planets around the Sun brings them so close together from the vantage point of Earth. But on May 5, 2000, all seven will be visible in the same part of the sky—although some at dawn and some at dusk and about ten times more spread out than on that late winter morning in 1953 B.C. Still, it's probably a good night for a party.

*After whom the European-American mission to the Saturn system is named.

*He so named it because of the words spoken by Miranda, the heroine of *The Tempest:* "O brave new world, That has such people in't." (To which Prospero replies, "Tis new to thee." Just so. Like all the other worlds in the Solar System, Miranda is about 4.5 billion years old.)